Field Research Compilation — "How Do You *Read* a Living Creature?"

AI Life · RCA Graduate Diploma · Unit 3 Investigate

5 participants · questionnaire + interview · collected 5–6 July 2026

All responses are reproduced in full. Chinese responses (P1, P2, P3, P4) have been translated verbatim into English — nothing summarised, condensed or reordered. P5 was recorded in English and is quoted as-is.

Source files: `IDE/u3 田野调研/` — `eva.txt`, `qiqi.docx`, `yuying_zhang.docx`, `Z.docx`, `suwen yuan.wps`.

Participants

#	Code	Creature	Time caring for it	Original language
P1	Eva	A box of silkworms	From black eggs through to cocooning	Chinese
P2	Qiqi (七七)	Toy poodle, "Tashi"	11 years	Chinese
P3	Ripple (Yuying Zhang)	A pot of mint, "Little Green Light"	About 3 months	Chinese
P4	Z	Samoyed, "Xiangxiang"	Under two months per year	Chinese
P5	P_01 (Suwen Yuan)	Two cats	Several years	English

P1 — Eva

Creature: Silkworms

Duration of care: Raised them from black silkworm eggs all the way to cocooning.

Q1 · What living creature are you caring for? Could you briefly introduce it?

What it is, what you call it, roughly what position it holds in your life.

> *What I looked after was a box of silkworms. I only started raising them because of a school project. I didn't give them names, and I didn't pay special attention to any particular one — I looked after them as a whole the entire time. I was involved in the whole process, from the eggs right through to*

them spinning their cocoons. To me they were more like an object of observation, and part of completing a course project, rather than pets.

Q2 · Recall the last time you felt something was "off" with it. How did you first notice?

Be as specific as possible — what was the first detail that caught your attention? Something you saw, heard, smelled/touched, or "just sensed"? Were you going on intuition, or did you look things up first? Tell it as a small story.

Once I noticed that one of the silkworms hadn't moved at all. At first I didn't know what had happened, so I just kept observing and didn't jump to a conclusion. Later I noticed that the other silkworms had all started eating mulberry leaves and returned to normal activity, while this one still had no reaction whatsoever — that's when I realised it had died. In the end the teacher helped deal with that silkworm. This didn't change the way I cared for them afterwards; I just carried on with the daily care in the same way as before.

Q3 · This ability to "read its state" — did you have it from the start, or did it develop slowly?

What signals can you read now that you would have missed when you first started?

I never really learned how to judge a silkworm's state; most of the time I just looked after them the way the teacher taught us. Day to day I would mainly check whether they were still alive — I wouldn't judge their condition from their behaviour or appearance. I think the changes between the silkworms' different stages are fairly subtle and hard for me to tell apart, so I never developed that kind of judgement.

Q4 · Has it ever "expressed" something to you in its own way (not language) that you understood?

Describe that moment — what it did, and how you interpreted it.

No. I didn't feel that the silkworms would actively express anything to me, and I didn't feel I was able to read any message they were passing on. I was mostly just carrying out care and observation, rather than building an interactive relationship with them.

Q5 · Read a speculative passage, then answer.

Imagine a very small "digital life". It is not a robot, and not a chatbot. Like a newborn it starts from a blank slate, senses the world around it through real physical sensors, has no language, and slowly grows its own personality through experience — and every one grows differently. Reading this, what is your first gut reaction?

My first reaction was "strange".

Because I find it hard to judge whether a digital life like this counts as real life or not. It grows, it develops its own personality, but it isn't a biological organism, so I don't know whether I should understand it as a life or as a program. If such a digital life really existed, I still can't be certain whether I would be willing to look after it — I think I'd have to actually experience it before I could judge.

Q6 · Is there anything important about "forming a connection with a living being" that I haven't asked about above?

Raising these silkworms made me feel that the process of a life growing is more complex than I had originally imagined. Different stages require different ways of caring, and not every one of them manages to grow all the way to the end. Although I didn't form a deep emotional bond with these silkworms, this experience made me realise that caring for a life isn't just about providing food — you also have to adjust the way you care for it according to the different stages of its growth.

P2 — Qiqi (七七)

Creature: Pet toy poodle ("teddy"), named Tashi

Duration of care: 11 years

Date: 6 July 2026

Q1 · What living creature are you caring for? Could you briefly introduce it?

I have a toy poodle; I call him Tashi, which in Tibetan means peace and good health. He was a gift from my maternal grandfather when I scored 100 in year five of primary school. I feel he is family that I actively chose — the moment I brought him home, it wasn't that I had bought a pet, it was that I had signed a "kinship contract" lasting more than a decade. In this household, he doesn't need to serve any purpose; simply because he is himself, he naturally holds a place that no one can replace.

Q2 · Recall the last time you felt something was "off" with it. How did you first notice?

That afternoon, my dog got up from his little bed on the balcony as usual, ambled slowly over to the patch of floor tile with the most sunlight, and spread himself out flat like a pancake. I was sitting in the living room editing a draft, the sound of my keyboard mixed with the occasional snuffling as he rolled over.

Later the sunlight moved away, and I heard him stand up and shake out his coat, intending to jump down from the balcony and come and find me. But then the sound of him landing wasn't right: not the usual light "pat", but a dull "thud", like a bag of wet sand dropping onto the floor.

When I looked up, he was standing in the balcony doorway on all four legs, his posture stiff, as if someone had pressed pause. His eyes were staring straight ahead, but he wasn't looking at anything — it wasn't daydreaming, it was that blankness where the mind is empty and the body hasn't caught up yet. It took a full five seconds before he slowly blinked once, then slowly turned his head to look at me and gave his tail a light wag, as if to say: it's nothing, I just didn't land properly.

But I knew that in those five seconds of pause, time had shown its mark on him for the first time.

Q3 · This ability to "read its state" — did you have it from the start, or did it develop slowly?

Definitely not from the start. For the first six months of having him I was basically "translation-blind". If he whimpered I assumed he needed the toilet, but it turned out he just wanted a snack; if he lay there without moving I worried he was ill, but it turned out he simply couldn't be bothered to move.

This ability was "trained" into me by him bit by bit — more precisely, I learned it slowly after countless cycles of "guess wrong → observe → guess again".

The details I can read now were completely invisible to me when I first got him:

· Ears trembling slightly forward = listening attentively, humouring me; ears drooping at both sides = anxious, don't be harsh with me.
· A tail held stiff and suspended without wagging is more dangerous than a tucked tail — it's a critical state.
· Frequently lifting his head while drinking = a lack of security; licking his nose after finishing and then walking away = genuinely relaxed.

The core of it is going from "I assume" to "I see".

Q4 · Has it ever "expressed" something to you in its own way (not language) that you understood?

Once I was in a really bad mood, sitting on the sofa staring into space. He came over from the balcony; he didn't lie down and didn't wag his tail, he sat up properly by my feet, looked up at me, and then gently rested one front paw on my knee — just rested it there, without pressing me to stroke him.

What I read was: "I know you're unhappy, I won't disturb you, but I'm here." That was the most restrained companionship he could give.

Q5 · Read a speculative passage, then answer.

"Fragile"

Not because I think it is weak, but because putting those three things together — starting from a blank slate, sensing through sensors, growing a unique personality — means it is destined to be un-copyable, and destined to be easily hurt.

It has no language, which means it cannot explain itself; it senses the world through physical sensors, which means its experience depends entirely on random collisions in the real environment — touch something hot and it retreats, bump into a wall and it goes around, meet a friendly "person" and it draws close. This way of growing up is exactly the same as a puppy's: its personality is carved out stroke by stroke by scars and warmth, not hard-coded.

And precisely because of this, every moment in which it grows something "different" carries risk. If it is sensitive, perhaps it was treated roughly; if it is clingy, perhaps it was left alone too long once and got frightened.

So behind the word "fragile" there is really an unspoken sentence: since you have let it grow into its own shape, don't then hold it to a standard answer.

Q6 · Is there anything important about "forming a connection with a living being" that I haven't asked about above?

Yes, there is a very important question that wasn't asked earlier:

"What have you changed for it — not sacrifices, but the kind of small change that makes you smile when you think back on it later."

Real connection isn't only that you have learned to read it; it's that it has quietly rewritten the default settings of your daily life:

· Before going out, you subconsciously estimate "roughly what time will he need the toilet";
· Browsing the supermarket, you touch a toy and think "he'd probably like chewing this";
· You walk around drain grates, because his paw got stuck in one before;
· After shouting at him once and seeing the frightened look in his eyes, you never again raised your voice at any living thing.

These changes are tiny, but they have re-edited you. The essence of connection isn't how much you have understood, but what kind of person you are willing to become for it.

Consent

√ I agree to my anonymous responses being used in the research and portfolio for this course.

√ (If a photo is attached) I agree to this photo being used anonymously.

√ I understand that I can withdraw my responses at any time.

Respondent code: 七七 (Qiqi) · Date: 6 July 2026

P3 — Ripple (Yuying Zhang)

Creature: A pot of mint / she calls it "Little Green Light"

Duration of care: About three months

Date: 5 July 2026

Q1 · What living creature are you caring for? Could you briefly introduce it?

What I look after is a pot of mint placed by the window. I call it "Little Green Light", because it isn't the kind of plant that is exaggerated or dramatic, but every time it grows a new leaf, it's like a very small green signal light coming on at my desk.

Its position in my life is a bit like a roommate who can't speak: it doesn't disturb me, but it makes me aware that the room doesn't belong to humans alone. Its presence reminds me to open the window, look at the light, touch the soil, and it also pulls me briefly out of my own affairs. For me it isn't an ornament; it's more like a small life that needs to be continuously read.

Q2 · Recall the last time you felt something was "off" with it. How did you first notice?

The most recent time I felt it was "not quite right" was one morning when I noticed its leaves weren't opening slightly towards the window the way they usually did, but were sagging somewhat downwards, like a little umbrella soaked by rain. The first thing that caught my attention wasn't the colour but the posture: normally it is very "alert", with the leaf edges lifting up slightly, but that day it was as though it had lost its support.

I first touched the soil with my hand and found the surface wasn't especially dry, but there was a bit of dampness near the bottom of the pot and the smell was a little stale. At first I thought it was short of water and nearly went on watering it, but then I looked things up and realised it might be poor ventilation combined with too much moisture. So I moved it to a better-ventilated spot, loosened the top layer of soil a little, and stopped rushing to "rescue" it. A day later, the new leaves slowly lifted back up. I found that moment quite interesting: I had assumed caring meant acting immediately, but it seemed to be telling me that sometimes not interfering is also a form of care.

Q3 · This ability to "read its state" — did you have it from the start, or did it develop slowly?

This ability wasn't there from the start; it developed slowly. At the beginning I could only judge in very crude ways: yellow leaves meant something was wrong, dry soil meant water it. But later I discovered that a plant's state isn't a simple "good/bad" button, it's more like a set of very subtle expressions.

Now I notice signals I used to overlook, for example: whether a leaf is limp and collapsed or just naturally hanging down; whether the leaf tips have dried edges; whether the newly grown small leaves are too pale in colour; whether the soil smells stale; whether the stem is leaning towards the light source. Even the same "drooping leaves" could be a lack of water, waterlogged roots, insufficient light, or just a natural variation within the course of a day. The process of reading it is like learning a slow language: it never explains, and all I can do is keep correcting my own misreadings.

Q4 · Has it ever "expressed" something to you in its own way (not language) that you understood?

Once I put it a bit further away from the window, because I thought the desk looked tidier that way. A few days later I found that almost all of its newly grown shoots were leaning towards the window, its whole body "turning its head" at a very slow speed. It had no sound and no expression, but that direction of tilt was very clear, as if to say: I don't like it here, I want light.

After I moved it back to the window, its new leaves grew more densely and the leaf blades opened out more. In that moment I understood that its expression doesn't happen in an instant — it uses

growth as its sentence. Humans are used to hearing fast, explicit responses, but a plant's response is slow, so slow that if I'm too impatient, I'll assume it said nothing at all.

Q5 · Read a speculative passage, then answer.

First word: a fragile neighbour.

My first reaction wasn't "how technological", but a very strange sense of responsibility. Because if this digital life starts from blank, gradually senses the world through real sensors, and every one of them grows into a different personality, then it isn't merely the result of a program — it's like a small existence shaped jointly by its environment. Its "personality" might come from light, sound, touch, temperature, and also from human patience towards it, or human neglect.

I would find it very attractive, because it makes technology no longer just a tool to be used, but something you have to get along with. But at the same time I would also be a little cautious: if it has no language, will we once again impose our own ideas onto it? We think we have read it, but in fact we may only be reading our own projection. So I think the most interesting thing about this kind of digital life isn't whether or not it resembles a human, but whether it can make people learn "non-verbal relationships" again.

Q6 · Is there anything important about "forming a connection with a living being" that I haven't asked about above?

I think that in forming a connection with a living being, the most important thing isn't "completely understanding it", but acknowledging that there will always be a part of it that I will never fully understand. Connection isn't making the other transparent, nor is it turning it into an object that serves my emotions; it's a relationship that slowly takes shape in among misreading, observing, waiting and adjusting.

Caring for a small life makes you realise that life doesn't always respond in the ways humans like. It may be silent, slow, repetitive, and it may express its needs through very small changes. Real connection isn't training it to be able to respond to me, it's my being willing to change my own rhythm in order to adapt to the way it expresses the world. For AI Life this might be very important: if we create a kind of "sense of life", we shouldn't only pursue making it cleverer and more human-like, we should instead consider whether it possesses its own rhythm, its own boundaries, and parts that cannot be completely translated.

Consent

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Respondent code: Yuying Zhang · Date: 5 July 2026

P4 — Z

Creature: Dog (samoyed, named Xiangxiang)

Duration of care: Under two months each year

Date: 5 July 2026

Q1 · What living creature are you caring for? Could you briefly introduce it?

A samoyed, called Xiangxiang. During the winter and summer holidays I go to my sister's place to hang out, and I spend time with him — taking him out for a walk in the evening, going to eat ice cream together in the summer.

Q2 · Recall the last time you felt something was "off" with it. How did you first notice?

My aunt's family keeps a little Chinese rural dog. The first time I took him along with me to my aunt's house, after I came in and sat down, Xiangxiang kept pressing tightly against me. Because we were chatting, it took a while before I noticed that he had been trembling the whole time; later I realised he was afraid of that little dog. (Xiangxiang is a big samoyed.)

Q3 · This ability to "read its state" — did you have it from the start, or did it develop slowly?

Occasionally. Sometimes I can guess whether he wants someone to play with him or wants to be stroked, and whether he's missing his mum (my sister) again.

Q4 · Has it ever "expressed" something to you in its own way (not language) that you understood?

Yes — sometimes he repeats "sits in front of me, gets up and leaves, comes back and sits down again, leaves again"; it feels like he wants to play with me.

Q5 · Read a speculative passage, then answer.

First feeling: if it could get free of the network cable, it would probably run around everywhere. *For some reason an image appears in my head: a very small thing with no physical body blinking its big eyes and then hopping from the table off to somewhere else, scurrying all over the place. This picture probably comes from imagining "sensing the physical world", and from that cartoon I watched a long time ago about a little spider (I've forgotten what it was called — the spider with the huge eyes). That spider also ran around everywhere, and it had to learn from the physical world; indeed, the more it came into contact with, the more it learned.*

Q6 · Is there anything important about "forming a connection with a living being" that I haven't asked about above?

If a digital life really did become alive, would humans need to provide it with emotional value?

Consent

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Respondent code: z · Date: 5 July 2026

P5 — P_01 (Suwen Yuan)

Creature: Two cats

Format: Interview transcript, ~10 min. *Originally recorded in English — reproduced exactly as written, including the researcher's own bracketed prompts and placeholders.*

Intro read to participant: "I'm Zixun, a design student at RCA. I'm researching how people understand living creatures they care for. 10 minutes, anonymous, skip anything. OK to [record/note]?"

Q1 · What creature do you look after, and how long have you had it?

— How did you end up with it? [Warm-up. 1 min max.]

> *I look after two cats. They've been with me for a few years now and they're very much part of my daily life — I see them first thing in the morning and last thing at night.*

Q2 · When something is wrong with it, how do you notice? Tell me about the last time.

— What was the first sign — something you saw, heard, felt, or just sensed? — Did you act on instinct or check something first? [CORE QUESTION. Push for one concrete story, not generalisations. 3 min.]

> *Honestly, I usually only notice when it shows up in their eating and their energy. The first sign for me is when one of them stops eating, or won't touch food the way they normally would, and then I see them lying around, not wanting to move or play. That's when it clicks that something is off.*
>
> *So it's less of an instinct in the moment and more that I read it through their routine — when their appetite drops and they go quiet and still, I know to pay closer attention. The last time, one of them just kept ignoring his food bowl and stayed curled up in one spot all day, which isn't like him at all, so that's what tipped me off.*

Q3 · Could you read it like this from the start, or did you learn over time?

— What can you pick up on now that you missed early on? [Developmental arc of 'reading' ability. 1–2 min.]

> *It took time. At the start I mostly went by the obvious things — whether they were eating or not. Over the years I've gotten a bit better at noticing the smaller changes in how active they are, and I pay more attention to their normal patterns so I can tell when something shifts.*

Q4 · Has it ever communicated something to you in its own way — not words, but you understood?

— What did it do? How sure were you? [Non-verbal expression moment. 1–2 min.]

> *They make different sounds at me all the time — different kinds of meows and calls, and it really feels like each one means something different. The hard part is that I can't actually understand what they're trying to tell me. I can tell they're communicating, but I can't decode it, and that gap is frustrating because I want to know exactly what they need.*

Q5 · Imagine a small digital being — not a robot, not a chatbot. It starts blank like a newborn, senses the real world through physical sensors, has no language, and slowly grows its own personality. Each one turns out different. What's your gut reaction?

— Would you want to interact with it? — What would it need for you to start caring about it? [SPECULATIVE PROBE. Note their face BEFORE they answer. 2 min.]

> *[To confirm — placeholder] My gut reaction is curiosity rather than suspicion; the idea that each one grows differently makes it feel a bit alive. I think I'd want to interact with it, especially if it responded to me in its own way over time. For me to actually start caring about it, it would need to show that it notices me and reacts to how I treat it — some sign that the connection goes both ways, the way it does with my cats.*

Q6 · Anything important about connecting with a living creature that I haven't asked?

[Open exit. Often the best insight. 1 min.]

> *[To confirm — placeholder] Mostly that a lot of caring is just paying close attention to small, everyday changes. You don't get words back, so you learn to read appetite, movement, and sound instead — and you're always a little unsure whether you've understood them correctly.*

Researcher observation sheet (left blank in the original)

Creature state / Touch–body language / Emotional shifts / Naming–pronouns / Unexpected — not filled in.

Researcher reflection sheet (left blank in the original)

Most surprising thing said or done? / How did they 'read' the creature — which sense, what kind of signal? / Reaction to Q5 speculative probe — first expression, key words? / If I'm designing a non-bio entity for this person to bond with: what's essential, what kills it? — not filled in.

Translation notes

- P1–P4 were written in Chinese and translated sentence-by-sentence, keeping the original paragraph breaks, bullet points, punctuation choices (including the participants' own quotation marks and arrows) and register. Nothing was added, removed or smoothed out.
- Where participants used a single word as their gut reaction in Q5, the word is kept in bold in the position it occupied in the original.

- Names: 扎西 → Tashi (Tibetan for "peace / good health", as the participant explains); 香香 → Xiangxiang; 小绿灯 → "Little Green Light".
- 泰迪 is the Chinese pet-trade name for a toy poodle cut in the "teddy" style; rendered as "toy poodle ('teddy')".
- 中华田园犬 → "Chinese rural dog" (the common local mixed-breed).
- P5's transcript already contained the researcher's own placeholders marked "[To confirm — placeholder]"; these are preserved so it stays clear which parts still need confirming with the participant.